Imparfait v/s Passé Composé

Completed v/s Incomplete Actions

When an action in the past has been successfully completed, use the **Passé Composé**; however, use the **Imparfait** to describe an incomplete past action that was not successfully completed.

For example: **J'ai appris le français** (Passé Composé) means that you have learned and mastered French and completed the learning process in a way that now you can speak it fluently. Whereas, **J'apprenais le français** (Imparfait) implies that you had started learning French in the past, but you gave up learning it before being able to master the language completely.

Concrete Actions in the past v/s Habitual Actions in the past

Passé Composé

Use the Passé Composé to talk about **Concrete Past Actions** such as describing one's daily routine, past work experiences in interviews, discussing one's last vacation and so on.

Routine activities
Je **me suis réveillé(e)** à 6h ce matin. Alors, j'ai **pris** une douche. Après, je **suis parti(e)** au bureau.

To describe a vacation
Je **suis allé(e)** à Paris. Je **suis resté(e) une** semaine dans un petit logement.

To talk about one's past work experiences
J'**ai travaillé** comme un(e) ingénieur(e). Je **me suis occupé(e)** d'une équipe informatique.

Imparfait

Use Imparfait to talk about your **past habits or behaviours that no longer exist in the present**. For instance:

J'allais à la salle de gym avant la pandémie. (I used to go to the gym before the pandemic, but I don't go anymore because gyms are closed.)

J'étais active et sportive. (I used to be active and sportive, but I am not anymore.)

Context v/s Principal Action

When the Passé Composé and the Imparfait are used together in a passage, **Imparfait** is used to **highlight the context or give a background** of the story, while the **Passé**

Composé is used to **describe the principal action/verb** in the story.

For example:
Le weekend dernier, **il faisait beau;** donc, **j'ai décidé** de faire du vélo.

Here, we have used the Imparfait to describe the weather/ the background or context while the Passé Composé to talk about the main action of riding a bike.

Principal Action v/s Secondary Action

While describing two actions occurring one after the other, we use the **Passé Composé** to describe the **principal action** and the **Imparfait** for referring to the **secondary action**.

For example:
Pendant que **je faisais du vélo** dans un parc, le chien **a coupé ma route et je suis tombée.**

Here, the main part of the story is the dog crossing my way and my fall due to dog. Therefore, the **principal action** is **le chien a coupé ma route et je suis tombée** whereas the **secondary action** is **pendant que je faisais du vélo dans un parc.**

Total Number of Times v/s Frequency of Occurrence

Use the **Passé Composé** to describe the **total number of times an event occurred**. To talk about the **frequency of occurrence**, use the **Imparfait**.

For example:
L'équipe de **l'Inde a gagné deux** fois la coupe du monde. (**In total**, India has won the world cup twice since 1983 till present.)

Dans les années 80, l'équipe de France **perdait** un match sur deux. (In the 80s, the French team lost **every second match.**)

Or

Avant le Covid, j'**allais** à la salle de sport trois fois par semaine. (**Frequency in a week**)

Dans ma vie, **je suis allé** à la salle de sport trois fois. (**Total number of times in entire life**)

Toujours/Jamais (Passé Composé v/s Imparfait)

Passé Composé

When we use toujours or jamais with the Passé Composé, it means that **the notion of 'always' or 'never' still exists in the present time**. For instance:

Avant **j'ai toujours voulu** être le meilleur (The notion of being the best still exists).

Or, **je n'ai jamais regardé** les séries françaises (It still holds true that I have never watched the French series).

Imparfait

Use the Imparfait to talk about **a notion which existed once**, **but does not exist anymore**. For example:

Avant, **je voulais** toujours être le meilleur (The notion of being the best does not exist now. I don't want to be the best now).

Je **ne regardais jamais** les séries françaises (At present, I have watched many French series, but earlier, I had never watched one).

Definite & Indefinite Duration

For **definite duration**, use the **Passé Composé**, while for **indefinite duration**, use the **Imparfait**. For instance:

J'ai travaillé à Paris de 2008 à 2010 (Time period is definite here).

Je travaillais à Madrid (We don't know since when).